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American Robin

Turdus migratorius

QUICK STATS

Length	7.9 – 11.0 in (20 – 28 cm)
Wingspan	12.2 – 15.7 in (31 – 40 cm)
Weight	2.7 – 3.0 oz (77 – 85 g)
Lifespan	Up to 14 years (avg. 2 in wild)

PRESENTATION

The American Robin is one of the most familiar and beloved birds in North America — a true symbol of spring whose return each year is eagerly anticipated across the continent. Plump, upright, and boldly patterned with its signature orange-red breast, it is a consummate garden bird, foraging confidently across lawns for earthworms and nesting on ledges, trees, and even window sills in close proximity to humans. Despite being called a robin, it is actually a thrush — a member of the same family as bluebirds and solitaires — and is the largest thrush in North America.

HABITAT & RANGE

The American Robin breeds across virtually all of North America, from Alaska and northern Canada south through Mexico, making it one of the continent's most widespread birds. It inhabits an extraordinary range of environments: lawns, parks, forests, mountains up to the treeline, tundra edges, and urban centers. Northern populations migrate south in autumn, though many winter in the southern US where berry-laden trees provide food. Year-round residents are common throughout much of the contiguous United States. Large winter flocks of thousands can gather in roosts.

DIET & FEEDING

- Earthworms — located by sight and sound, not smell
- Wild berries: holly, crabapple, juniper, dogwood, cedar
- Insects, beetles, grasshoppers, and caterpillars
- Fruit: grapes, cherries, plums, serviceberry
- Rarely visits seed feeders — prefers open ground foraging
- Plant berry-producing shrubs to attract robins to your garden

BEHAVIOR & SOCIAL LIFE

American Robins are highly visible and active birds, spending much of their time foraging on the ground with a characteristic run-stop-tilt posture as they listen and watch for earthworms. Contrary to popular belief, they locate worms primarily by sight rather than hearing, though both senses play a role. Outside breeding season, robins are highly gregarious, forming communal roosts of thousands or even millions of birds in woodlands. These roosts disperse each morning as birds fan out to forage, then reconvene at dusk. Males arrive on breeding grounds before females each spring and immediately begin singing to establish territories.

NESTING & BREEDING

The American Robin is one of the earliest nesters in North America, often beginning as soon as late February in the South. The female builds a robust cup nest of grasses, twigs, and worm castings, reinforced with mud and lined with fine grasses. Nests are placed on building ledges, in tree forks, or on fence posts 5–15 feet above ground. The female lays 3–5 eggs of a vivid, unmistakable sky blue — the origin of the color name "robin's egg blue." Incubation lasts 12–14 days. Both parents feed nestlings, which fledge at 13 days. Pairs typically raise 2–3 broods per season.

SONG & COMMUNICATION

The robin's song is one of the most recognized sounds of the North American spring — a rich, melodious caroling of rising and falling phrases often transcribed as "cheerily, cheer-up, cheerio." Males begin singing before dawn and continue into dusk, sometimes even singing after dark near artificial lights. The sharp "tut-tut-tut" alarm call warns of ground predators, while a high thin "seee" alerts to aerial threats. Robins are among the first birds to sing in the morning chorus.

CONSERVATION STATUS

IUCN Red List:	Least Concern	Population trend:	Stable
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With an estimated population of 300 million individuals, the American Robin is one of the most abundant birds in North America. Its adaptability to human-modified landscapes has helped it thrive despite widespread habitat changes. It does face localized threats from pesticide use, which reduces earthworm availability and can cause direct poisoning.

FEEDER TIPS

- Robins rarely use seed feeders — attract them differently
- Install a shallow birdbath: robins love to bathe and drink
- Plant holly, crabapple, dogwood, or serviceberry for winter berries
- Avoid pesticides on lawns — robins depend on healthy earthworm populations
- A platform feeder with mealworms or fruit pieces may attract them

COLORING GUIDE

ZONE	RECOMMENDED COLOR
Head & back	Dark gray to black
Breast & belly	Brick orange-red
Throat	White with dark streaks
White eye-ring	Pure white crescent
Bill	Yellow-orange
Legs & feet	Dark brown-gray

COLOR ME!

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